GLOBAL EQUITY STRATEGY

2026 Outlook: Tech Tonic — a broadening bull market

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- **We remain constructive on equities for 2026 as earnings continue to grow, but forecast lower index returns than in 2025, amid a broadening bull market.**
- This fits with our economic outlook, where we expect continued economic expansion in all regions combined with further modest easing by the US Federal Reserve. Given this macro backdrop, it would be unusual to see a significant equity setback/bear market without a recession, even from elevated valuations.
- Our 12-month equity forecasts, weighted by regional market cap, would give 13% price returns in 2026, 15% with dividends, in USD. Most of these returns are earnings-driven. The late-cycle 'Optimism' phase also typically sees rising valuations, suggesting some upside risks to our central forecasts.
- **Despite the intense investor focus on AI, this has been a good year to diversify.** There has been a trend of US underperformance for the first time in nearly fifteen years, while factor diversification is working (Growth has remained dominant in the US, while Value has performed better in Europe), and there is a broadening out of sector returns with many non-tech sectors performing strongly.
- **Given that equities remain concentrated by geography, sector and stock (particularly in the US), we continue to look for diversification opportunities.** We think this will result in better risk-adjusted returns and would therefore seek broad geographical exposure, together with a mix of Growth and Value exposures. We also focus on increased alpha, as stock correlations have fallen and are likely to remain low. In summary, we recommend that investors:
- **Stay invested, diversify across regions (with an increased focus on EM), across factors (combining selective Growth and Value), and across sectors (to benefit from positive spillovers from tech capex spend and the rising focus on AI beneficiaries outside of the tech sector); focus on alpha to take advantage of lower stock concentrations.**

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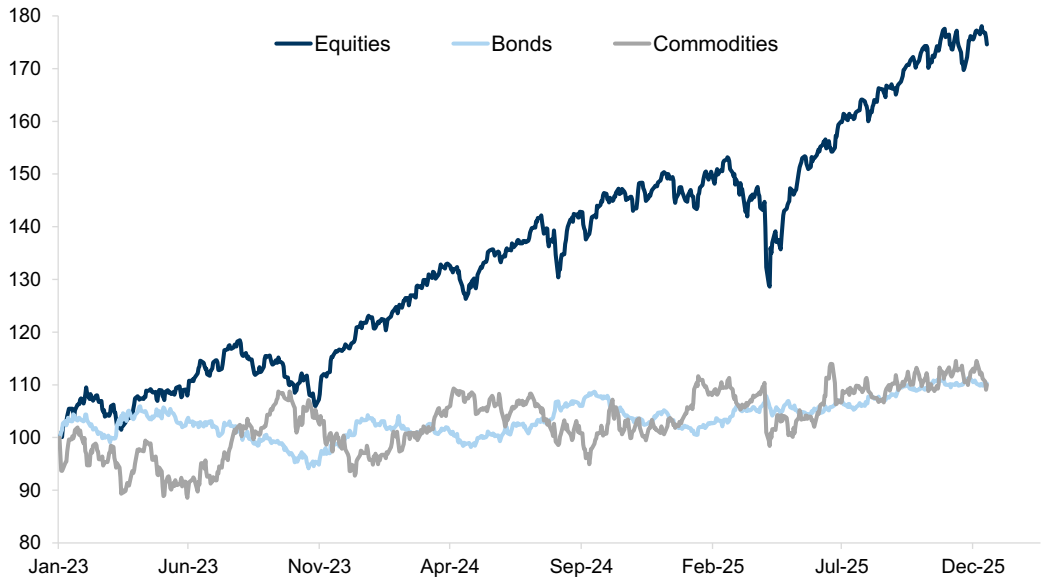
Tech Tonic — a broadening bull market

1. Equities have performed strongly this year, comfortably outperforming bonds and commodities (Exhibit 1). But progress has not been in a straight line. The S&P 500 (which underperformed early in the year) experienced a correction of just under 20% between the middle of February and April, while the Nasdaq fell almost 25%. A combination of tariff concerns and the spillover effects on the US technology sector from the introduction of DeepSeek were the key drivers.

Exhibit 1: Equities have outperformed bonds and commodities this year
Indexed USD total returns; Equities refer to MSCI AC World, Commodities refer to S&P GSCI® & Bonds refer to US 10y Govt. bonds



Source: Datastream, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

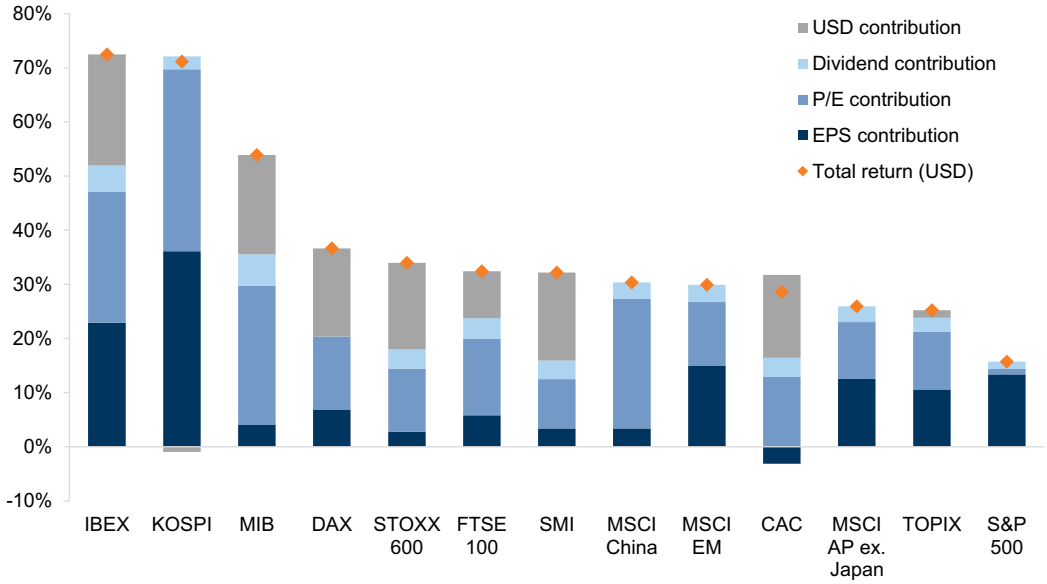
The recovery since the April trough has been dramatic; the two US indices have rebounded by close to 45% since the trough. Better than feared economic data have pushed up growth expectations, with Cyclicals performing strongly relative to Defensive stocks. A fading of tariff concerns and strong earnings results (particularly for US mega cap tech) have also helped drive markets higher.

2. Our main theme for 2025 has been to diversify given that we came into this year with record country, sector and stock concentration. Most major equity markets have outperformed the US in 2025 (Exhibit 2) as geographic diversification has, for the first time in many years, benefited investors. Europe, China and Asia have generated almost double the total returns compared with the US in dollar terms. Specific markets within the broader regions, such as Italy (54%), Spain (73%) and Korea (71%), have been particularly strong. We have also seen many EM markets start to break out on the upside, supported by stronger earnings growth and a tailwind from lower US interest rates and the dollar. We expect this trend to continue.

While most equity markets have made good progress in 2025, the drivers have varied. In the US, equity markets have been driven by strong earnings (particularly in the tech space), whereas in other markets there has been a more even balance between

improving earnings and rising valuations, with Europe seeing the biggest contribution of returns coming from valuation re-rating.

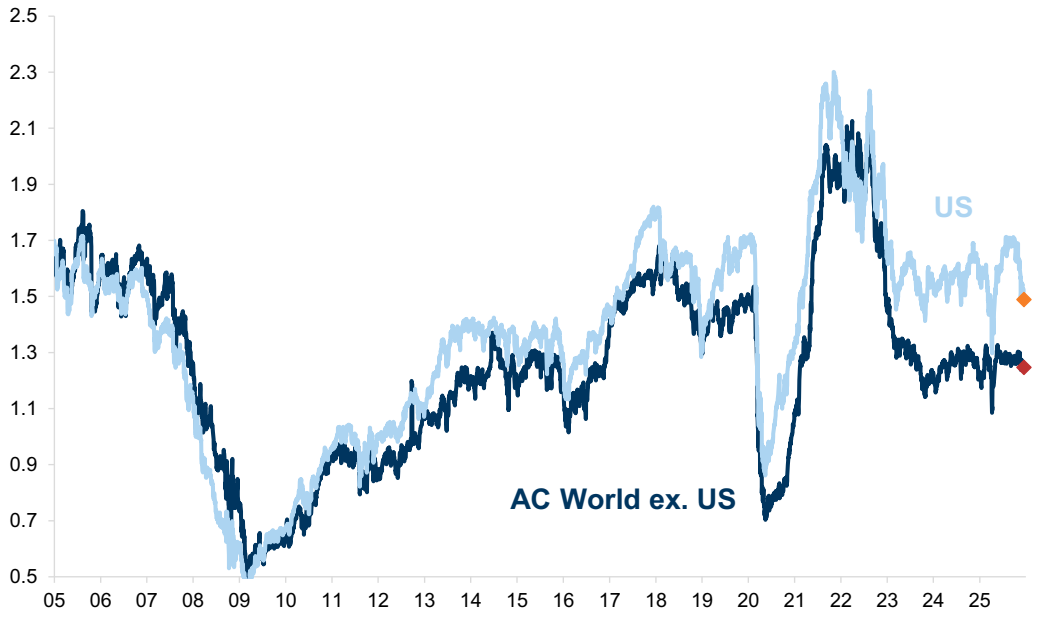
Exhibit 2: Nearly all major equity markets have outperformed the US in 2025 in local and in USD terms
Decomposition of YTD return in USD



Source: Datastream, STOXX, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

The broadening of equity returns in 2025 has started to narrow the PEG ratio gap between the US and the rest of the world (Exhibit 3) (which widened after the pandemic and particularly following Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine and the introduction of ChatGPT). We expect these growth-adjusted valuation ratios to continue to converge in 2026, even as absolute valuations in the US remain higher.

Exhibit 3: The PEG ratio between US and the rest of the world has gradually started to close
PEG ratio (12m fwd P/E divided by second 12m fwd EPS growth)



Source: Datastream, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

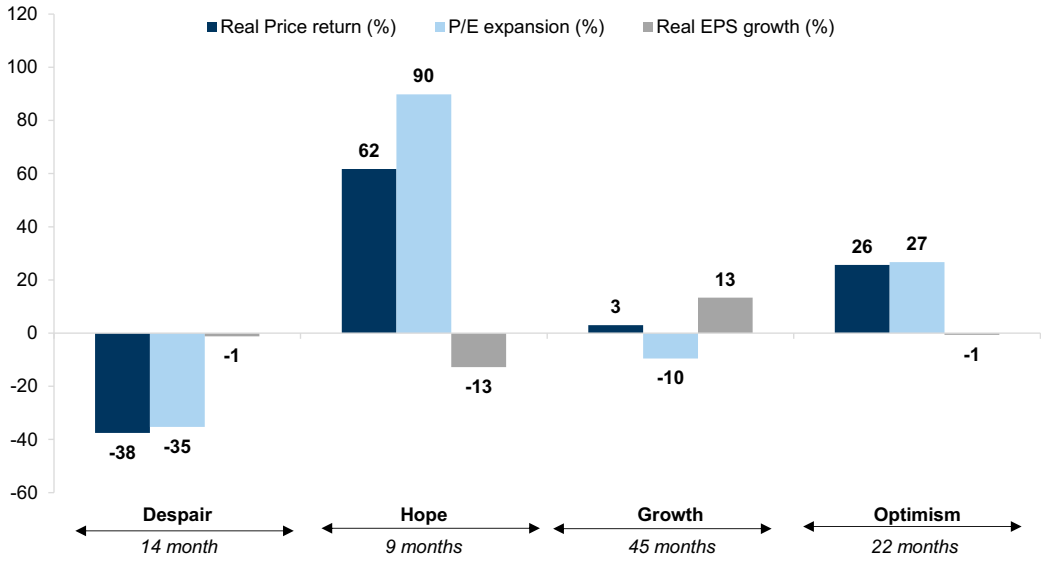
3. In our view, we are in an 'Optimism' phase of the cycle. In our work on cycles, we find strong evidence that markets evolve through various phases of a typical equity cycle. Most of these oscillate around economic cycles and can vary significantly in length and strength. Nonetheless, we find that there are repeated patterns in which the cycles move through phases. Exhibit 4 shows the average of experiences in the US equity market in cycles going back over 50 years, but it also shows how distinct phases reflect the extent to which the index price performance is driven by actual profit growth when it emerges and/or by expectations of future profit growth, which we can measure as changes in the P/E multiple (valuations rise as investors anticipate future improvements in profit growth and decline when they anticipate weaker growth).

For simplicity, the four phases can be described as follows: (i) The **'Despair'** phase, or bear market, when the market moves from its peak to its trough, typically lasts an average of just over a year, and stocks tend to fall by between 30% and 40%. (ii) The **'Hope'** phase, typically a short period when the market rebounds from its trough valuation, or P/E multiple expansion, is typically the strongest, and lasts between 6 and 12 months. (iii) The **'Growth'** phase, usually the longest period (on average 45 months in the US), when earnings growth is generated and drives returns. (iv) The **'Optimism'** phase, the final part of the cycle, when investors become increasingly confident, or perhaps even complacent, and where valuations tend to rise again and outstrip earnings growth.

If we take the current cycle as having started during the bear market triggered by Covid (which pushed the global economic cycle off course, triggering a global recession), we see a fairly typical evolution of the cycle (Exhibit 5). That said, we see the Covid-driven bear market as 'event'-driven (event-driven bear markets tend to be much shorter than the more standard 'cyclical' bear markets). 2025 has been a good example of the early Optimism phase where many equity markets

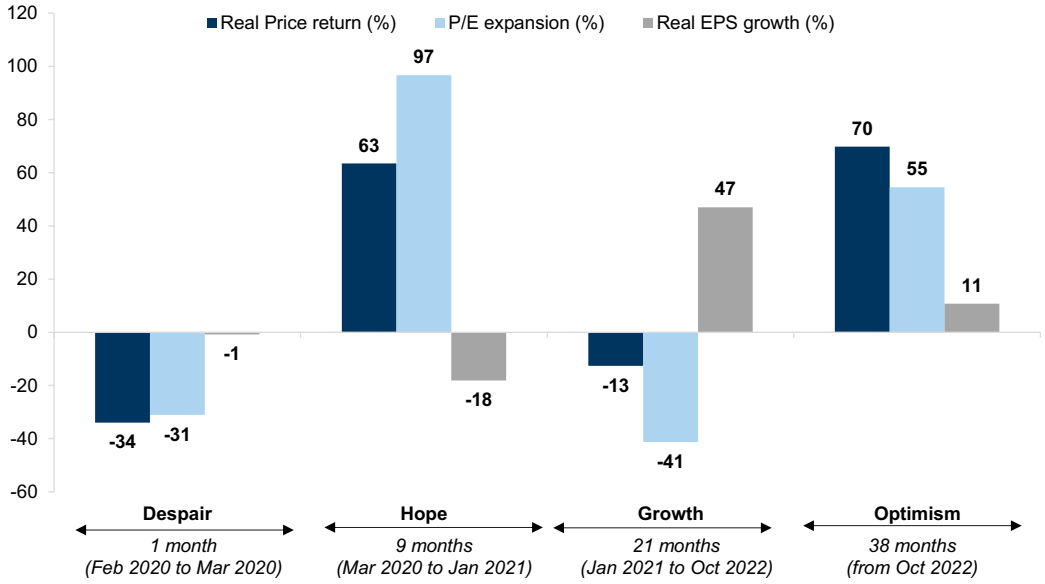
(particularly outside of the US, where valuations were much lower) have seen valuations rise with earnings. We believe that the Optimism phase will continue in 2026.

Exhibit 4: The four phases of an equity cycle
Annualised data for historical phases (S&P 500, 1970s-present)



Source: Datastream, Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

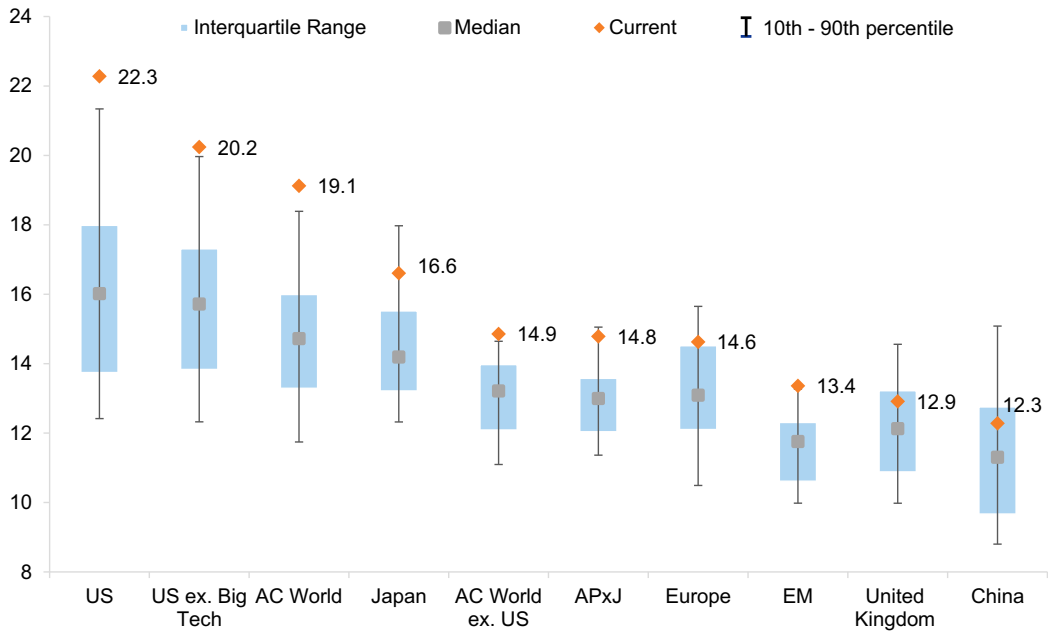
Exhibit 5: The four phases of the current cycle
Cumulative data for current phase (S&P 500)



Source: Datastream, Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

4. While markets are likely to continue to rise in 2026, valuations are now high across the equity complex in each region compared with history (Exhibit 6).

Exhibit 6: Equity valuations across regions are now at historical highs
12m fwd P/E multiple. MSCI Regions, STOXX 600 for Europe and S&P 500 for US. Data for the last 20 years.

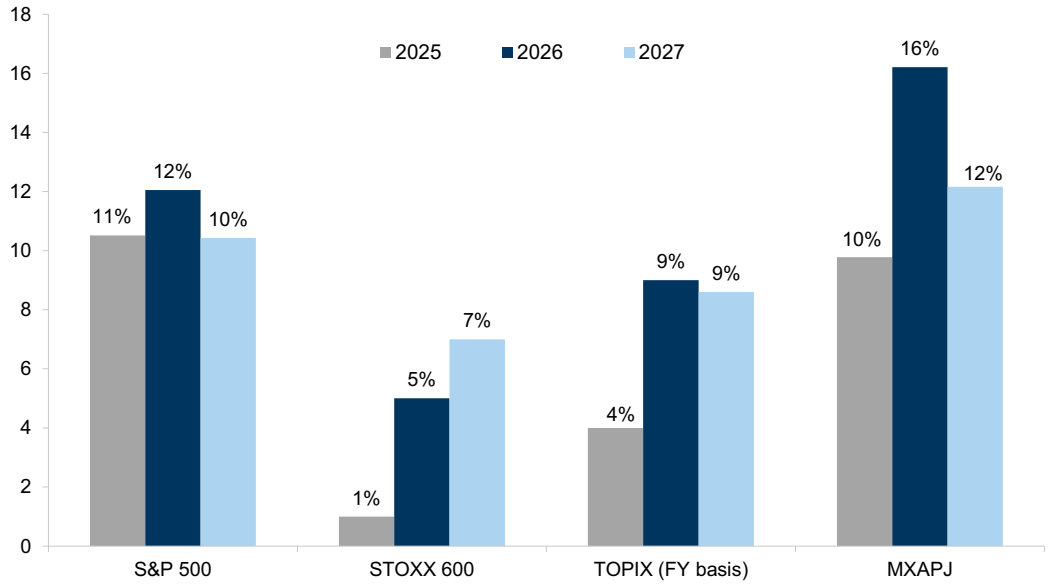


Source: FactSet, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Consequently, we think that returns in 2026 are likely to be driven more by fundamental profit growth rather than by rising valuations. As Exhibit 7 shows, our earnings models suggest continued positive earnings growth in 2026 – stronger than the pace of 2025 earnings growth in all regions. That said, we are below the bottom-up consensus in most regions; we find the bottom-up consensus is oftentimes overly optimistic at the outset of each year and in aggregate is unlikely to reflect what most investors expect.

In Europe, we are significantly below bottom-up consensus, although this is largely a function of currency translation; for example, roughly 60% of the earnings are generated outside of Europe and are weaker as a result of a stronger Euro in our forecasts (EUR/USD 1.25 over 12 months). That said, we do expect slightly better growth further out, and forecast 5% and 7% STOXX Europe EPS growth in 2026 and 2027, respectively, with 2027 not seeing the drag from FX.

Exhibit 7: Our earnings models point to moderate profit growth ahead
GS top-down estimates of 2025, 2026, 2027 EPS growth



Source: I/B/E/S, Toyo Keizai, STOXX, MSCI, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

On balance, however, the growth numbers, coupled with dividends, are likely to drive reasonable returns in equities, particularly in USD terms, where we again see the US equity market underperforming in 2026 (Exhibit 8). Overall, however, despite the higher-than-average valuations across equity markets, there is potential for upside risks to our central forecasts if investor optimism, driven by the AI and easing narratives, triggers further valuation expansion, in common with most Optimism phases of bull markets.

Also, we roll on and raise our 3, 6 and 12m forecasts for STOXX Europe to 590, 600 and 615 (previously 575, 580, 595). All price return is earnings-driven.

Exhibit 8: We see potential upside for global equities in 2026, with the US market expected to marginally underperform
Return forecasts for 2026 with Consensus estimates for dividends. Data as of December 16th, 2025.

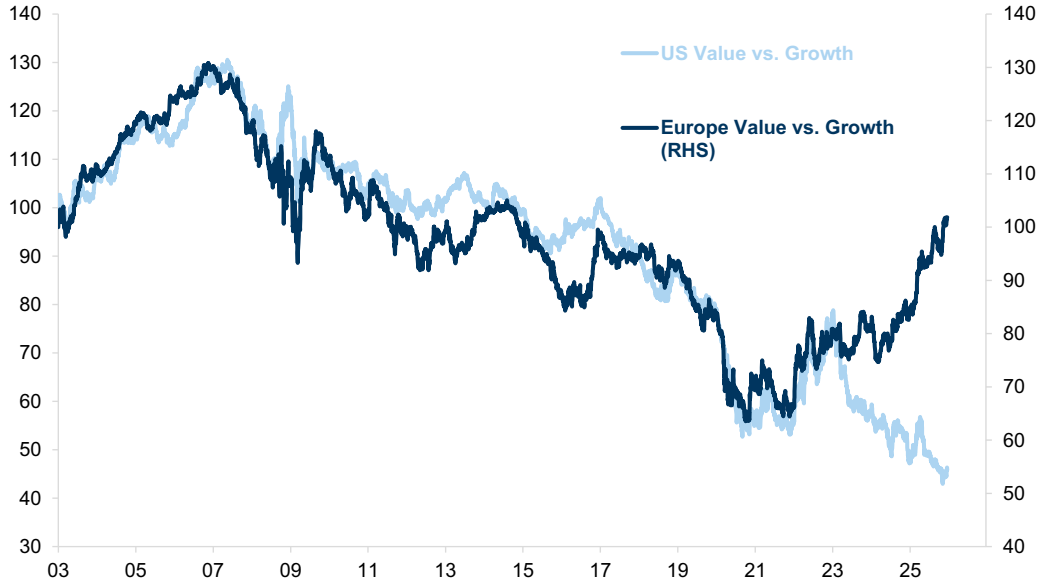
		2026 Forecasts				
	Current	Price target	Price return	Total returns	Returns in USD	EPS growth
S&P 500	6721	7,600	13%	15%	15%	12%
STOXX 600	580	615	6%	9%	16%	5%
TOPIX	3369	3,600	7%	9%	12%	9%
MSCI AP ex Japan	699	805	15%	18%	18%	16%
MSCI EM	1359	1,565	15%	18%	18%	17%

Source: Datastream, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

5. While diversification has been working across regions in 2025, it has also started to work across styles and sectors. For example, while the Growth factor has continued to outperform in the US, Value has generally done better outside of the US (Exhibit 9), marking a more idiosyncratic pattern relative to the past decade when most markets were driven by the outperformance of Growth. Partly, this reflects the improved fundamentals in several value sectors that have successfully transitioned from 'Value

traps' to Value generators (such as financials and mining). It also is a function of the scale up in tech capex spilling over into better growth prospects in several 'old economy' infrastructure-related areas of the market. As our US strategists note, the seven largest stocks in the S&P 500 (NVDA, AAPL, MSFT, GOOGL, AMZN, AVGO, META) account for 36% of S&P 500 market cap and 26% of earnings, and should contribute 46% of index EPS growth in 2026. While still very large, this represents a decline from their 50% contribution in 2025 as earnings growth for the S&P 493 accelerates from +7% in 2025 to +9% in 2026.

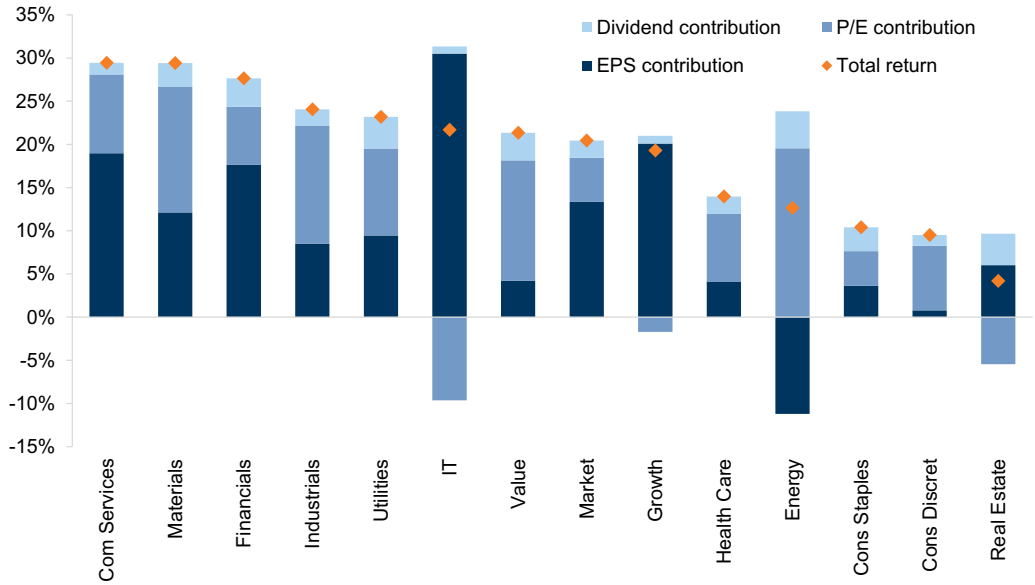
Exhibit 9: Value vs. Growth dynamics have been diverging between the US and Europe
Total return. Indexed to 100 in Jan 2003



Source: Datastream, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

There has also been a broadening of returns across sectors with unusual combinations leading and lagging the returns rankings (Exhibit 10). For example, technology and financials have been among the strongest performers (a Growth and a Value sector), while real estate and healthcare have lagged (a cyclical and a defensive sector). **This reflects the fact that parts of Growth and parts of the Value complex have done well together. As with country returns, however, there has been a wide distribution of drivers across sectors. IT has continued to be driven largely by fundamental earnings growth, whereas some other sectors have seen a great contribution from valuation expansion, particularly in the Value style (which is also more dominant in several non-US markets).**

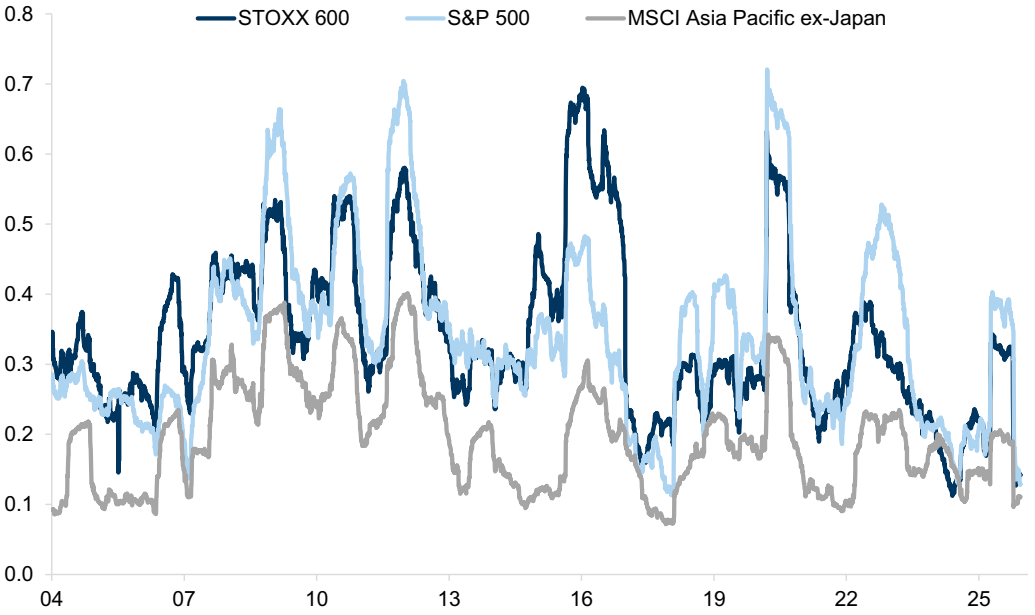
Exhibit 10: Sector/style performances also reflect broad diversification
MSCI AC World YTD return contribution by sector/style in USD



Source: FactSet, Datastream, STOXX, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

6. As index valuations rise and sector returns broaden, we are also seeing greater opportunities for alpha generation. Stock correlation has been falling in most markets. A fall in stock pairwise correlations (Exhibit 11), pointing to more idiosyncratic risk in equity markets, is also consistent with a broadening of opportunities for investors to diversify.

Exhibit 11: Pairwise correlations on a 6-month rolling basis have fallen, suggesting a more attractive opportunity set for alpha generation
6m Average pairwise correlation

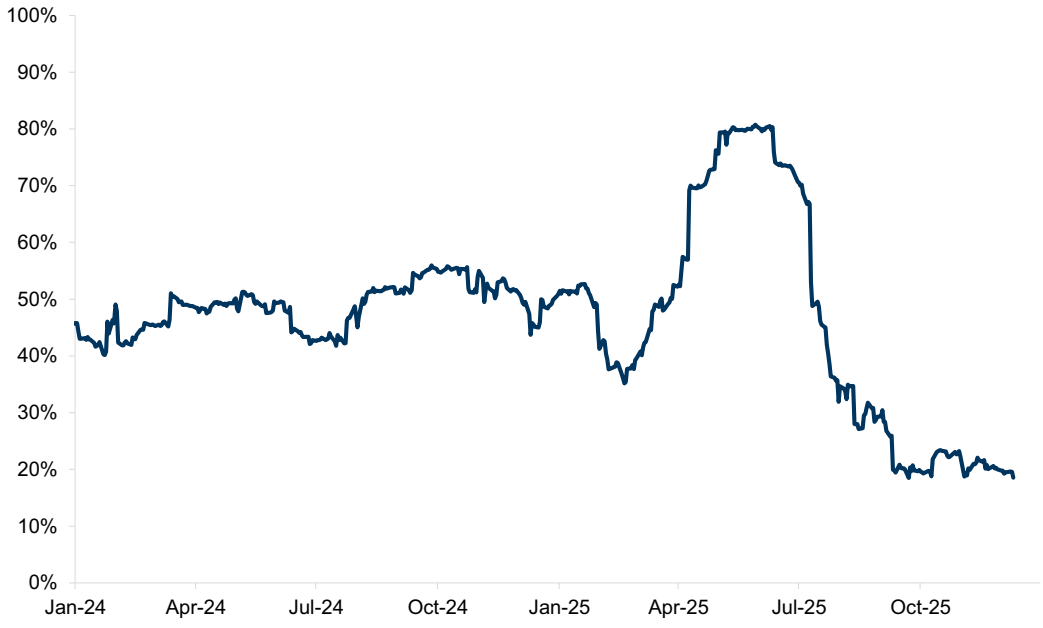


Source: Bloomberg, FactSet, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

The falls in stock correlation have been seen in most sectors, including in US technology

and across the hyperscalers. As our US strategists wrote, the dispersion of share price reactions to increased spending estimates has demonstrated heightened investor scrutiny on capex spending. The average stock price correlation across the large public AI hyperscalers has declined from 80% in June to just 20% today (Exhibit 12). **This suggests that diversification should also work within the technology space.**

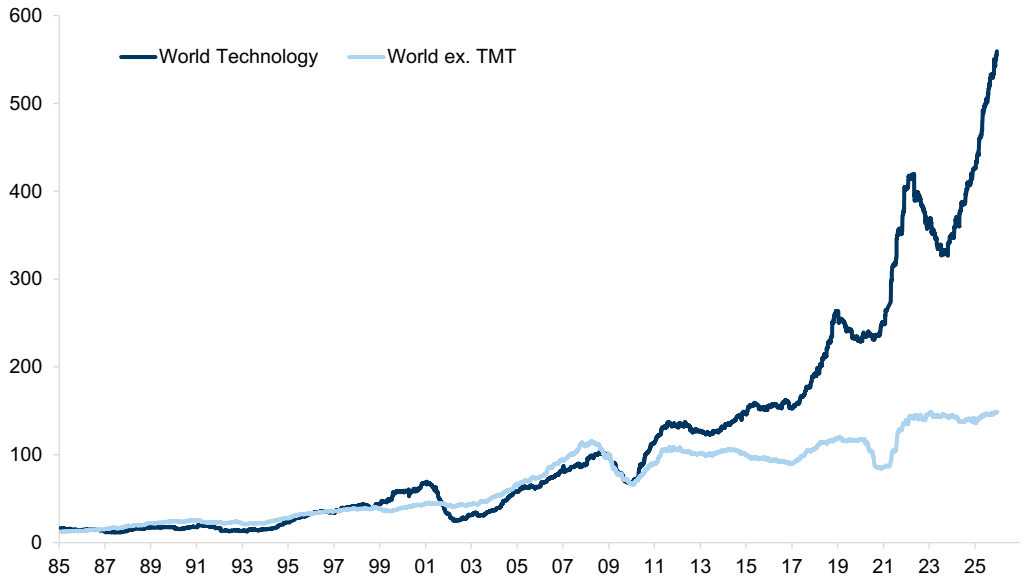
Exhibit 12: The large AI hyperscalers have become less correlated to each other
3-month realised average pairwise correlation of large public AI hyperscalers (AMZN, GOOGL, META, MSFT, ORCL) stock returns



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

7. Despite the improved returns in non-US equities this year, and also in sectors outside of technology, market focus on AI remains intense. While stock prices have increased sharply (NVIDIA, for example, has seen its stock price rise by around 1,000% since the release of ChatGPT three years ago), this does not yet represent a bubble in our view. **The tech sector's dominance of markets has not been triggered by the emergence of AI.** It began after the financial crisis and has been supported by superior profit growth (Exhibit 13).

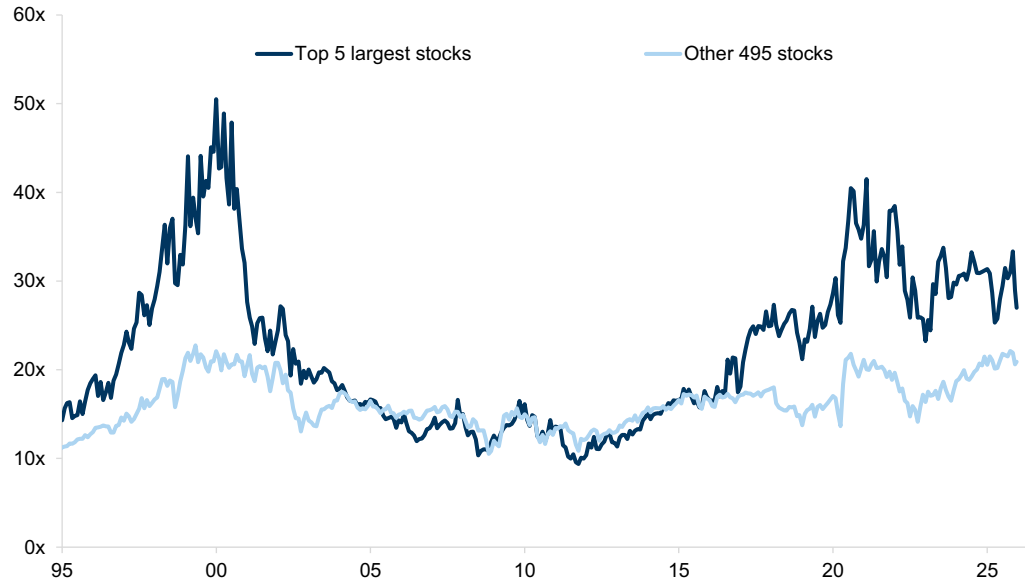
Exhibit 13: Tech earnings have outstripped those of the global market
12m trailing EPS (USD). Indexed to 100 on Jan-2009



Source: Datastream, Worldscope, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Valuations are also not as extreme as in other bubble periods. As Exhibit 14 shows, these have a much more moderate valuation that the five largest companies at the peak of the past cycle (despite having stronger balance sheets and being more profitable). The rest of the market has a much lower multiple, although still the highest since the peak in 2000.

Exhibit 14: Market valuations are more balanced than in previous bubbles, with the top 5 stocks maintaining a moderate premium
S&P 500 12m forward P/E multiple

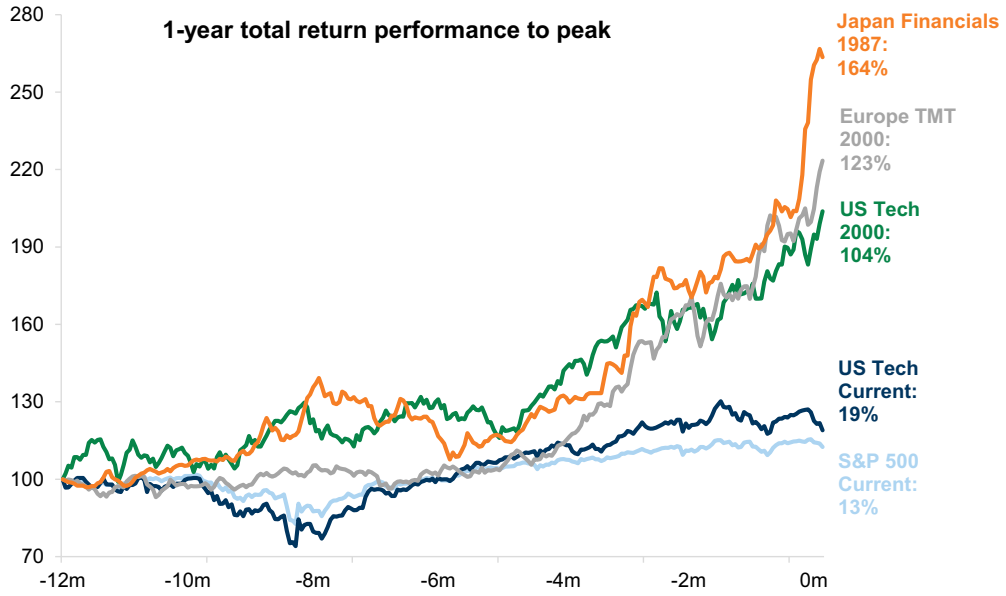


Source: FactSet, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Furthermore, the returns that we have seen in this sector over this past year have been

much more modest than experienced in previous bubble periods. **The ascent of technology in terms of size and influence, particularly in the US equity market, has been a function of extraordinary fundamental growth rather than irrational speculation about the future.** In past bubbles, too, speculation was far more extreme, with more significant stock price rises into the final year of the bubble (Exhibit 15).

Exhibit 15: Past bubbles saw much larger stock price surges in their final year
1-year total return performance to peak



Source: Datastream, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

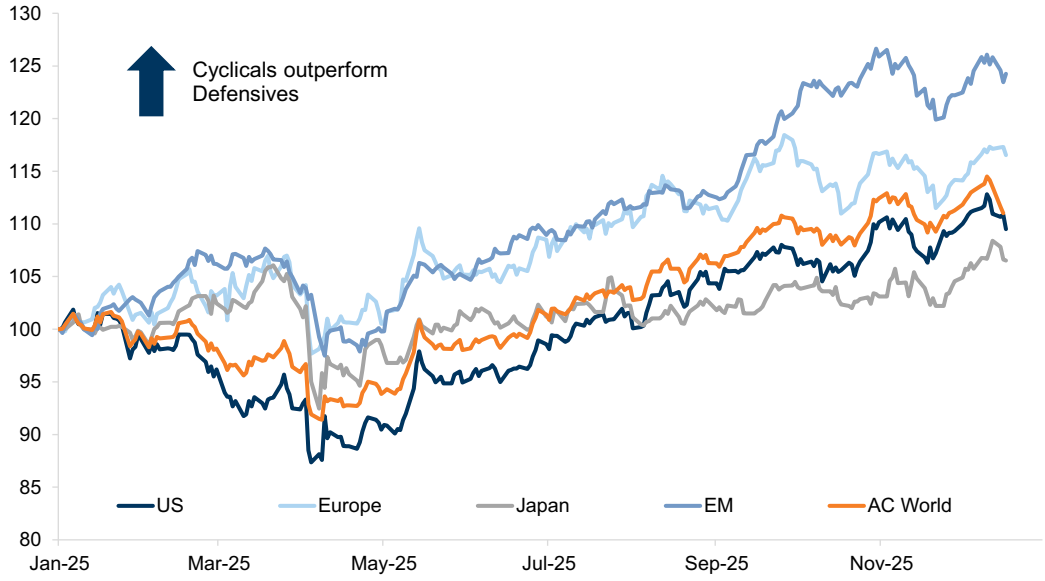
For example, when search engine company Yahoo! had its Initial Public Offering, its stock price rose from $13 to $33 in a single day. In 1999, 13 major large-cap stocks increased in value by over 1,000%, and another seven large cap stocks each rose by over 900%. The Nasdaq index increased fivefold over the period between 1995 and 2000. In Japan in the late 1980s, the rampant speculation in land prices reportedly resulted in the Imperial Palace in Tokyo reaching a land value greater than that of California, and the value of land in the country was theoretically worth more than four times that of the whole of the United States (despite the latter being 25 times bigger). These levels of exuberance are not generally reflected in the current valuations across technology.

While there are reasons to be cautious about the returns that are likely to be achieved on the back of the surge in capex by the hyperscalers, much of this has so far been driven by free cash flow. Nevertheless, debt financing and vendor financing models are becoming more prominent and suggest that the sector is becoming more risky. Net supply from AI-related issuers in the USD credit market has crossed $200 billion in 2025, more than doubling last year's total and now accounting for 30% of total net issuance in 2025. (see: Credit Notes: What we took away from 2025). The fall in stock correlation within the tech sector is a reflection of investors putting more scrutiny on companies as they determine who will be a relative winner or loser, rather than continuing to imply that all will win equally. **It is also a reflection of how investors are starting to focus more on potential beneficiaries of AI outside of the hyperscalers. This includes the application layer and, in our view, investors will increasingly focus on companies outside of the technology sector that can best leverage AI and its related**

technologies to improve margins and productivity over the course of 2026.

8. What are the risks? One risk is weaker economic growth, a source of which could come from rising unemployment, leading to a correction. This is particularly relevant given strong performance in equities this year, higher-than-average valuations, and the consistent outperformance of more cyclical parts of the equity markets (Exhibit 16). Nevertheless, there are two supportive factors for investors. First, there is room for interest rates to fall more quickly than the market is pricing, particularly in the US.

Exhibit 16: Cyclicals have outperformed
MSCI Indices relative price return (USD)



For details on the construction of the indices, please see: Cyclicals vs. Defensives: A global implementation

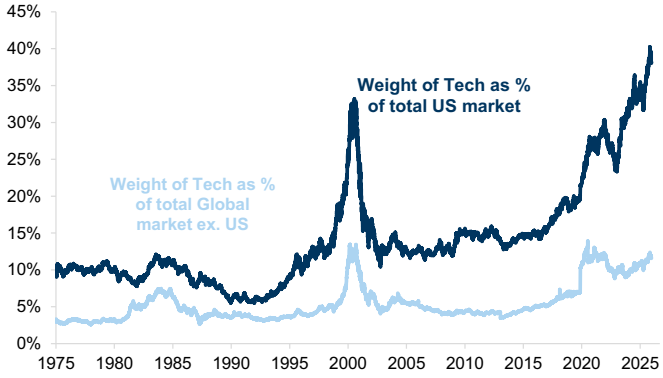
Source: Datastream, Worldscope, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Second, private sector balance sheets are relatively healthy and banks' balance sheets are strong. This would not prevent a recession, but should limit the second-round effects that often deepen and prolong a downturn. **There are, of course, also risks to the upside as a combination of easing financial conditions, a weaker dollar, ongoing economic strength (particularly in the US and China), and further interest in AI could lead to higher valuations in equities in 2026.**

9. What about the risks related to concentration?

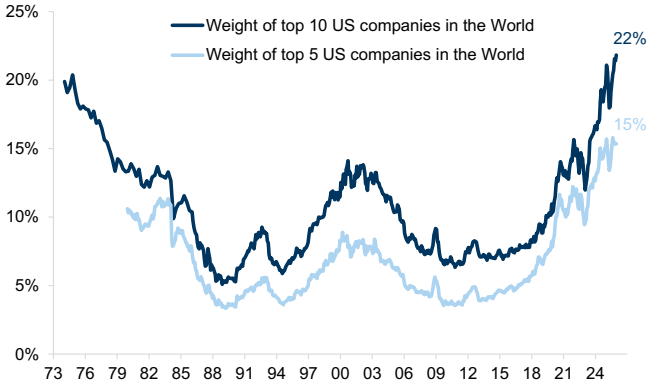
A disappointing quarter for technology stocks, or indeed the emergence of more competition, could trigger a pullback in leading tech stocks. Given the weight of the technology sector (Exhibit 17) and of the biggest technology companies in the global market (Exhibit 18), and in the US equity market in particular, this would be sufficient to trigger a correction.

Exhibit 17: Technology represents a higher share of the US market than it does in other regions
Weight of the technology sector



Source: Datastream, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 18: In the US the biggest 10 companies account for almost a quarter of the value of the global equity market
Weight of biggest US companies in global market cap

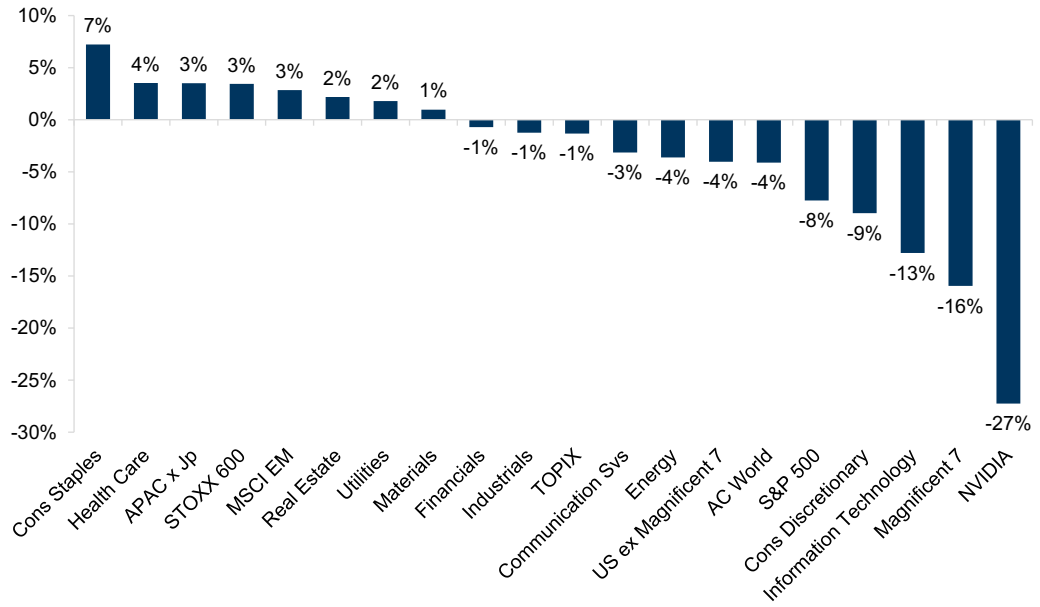


Source: Datastream, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

We saw the effects of this type of correction earlier this year following the release of DeepSeek **in Q1 2025, which shook the tech world as it raised the prospect of new competition** able to deliver competitive performance at a fraction of the cost, fuelling concerns about US AI dominance. Nevertheless,

1. **The damage was concentrated in tech, not systemic.** The Magnificent 7 were the clear laggards, with NVIDIA collapsing into bear market territory (-27%, see Exhibit 19). The rest of the market was broadly stable; even utilities outperformed despite their usual AI-linked behaviour.
2. **The broader market barely moved.** During this correction, the S&P 500 fell 8%, but only 4% excluding the Magnificent 7. Asia outperformed, supported by its own Chinese tech space, while Europe—with its limited tech exposure—led global peers.
3. **Positioning followed a classic playbook.** Defensives outperformed Cyclicals, Value outperformed Growth, and regional rotation favoured non-US equities. We see the risks of a tech-driven correction as high, but do not believe this would be systemic for the broader markets; **we would remain invested and hedge this risk through more diversified exposure.**

Exhibit 19: The "DeepSeek moment"
Performance from 22-Jan-2025 to 10-Mar-2025



Source: Datastream, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

10. Is credit and government debt a risk? Yes, the risks in private credit markets are rising given the ramp up in credit issuance by tech companies and also fears of loosening credit standards. The failures of Tricolor and First Brands have increased focus on the possible risks, and further weakness in this area could result in sharper rises in credit spreads. Additionally, worries about public finances could also prompt a sharp rise in government bond yields. In either case, given low equity risk premia, this could result in a pullback in equities, and simultaneously in credit and fixed income markets, making it a harder risk to hedge.

In summary, we continue to expect higher equity markets in 2026, but with lower index returns than in 2025. A backdrop of continued economic growth and lower US interest rates, a modestly weaker US dollar and fiscal support across a number of economies suggests that the bull market is likely to have further to run, and **in the Optimism phase of the cycle, when markets tend to be strong, there is a risk of a further 'melt up' if the AI-driven narrative triggers more speculative behaviour, and we see more evidence of a bubble. Given that equities are concentrated by geography (dominated by the US), sector (dominated by tech), and at the stock level (dominated by the US hyperscalers), we continue to look for diversification opportunities. We think this will result in better risk-adjusted returns and would seek broad geographical exposure, together with a mix of Growth and Value exposures. We also focus on increased alpha as stock correlations are likely to remain low. In summary, we recommend investors:**

- **Stay invested.**
- **Diversify across regions with a greater focus on EM.**
- **Diversify across factors (combining selected Growth and Value stocks).**
- **Diversify across sectors (to benefit from positive spillovers from tech capex**

spend to potential AI beneficiaries).

- **Focus on alpha to take advantage of lower stock concentrations.**

Disclosure Appendix

Reg AC

We, Peter Oppenheimer, Sharon Bell, Guillaume Jaisson and Giovanni Ferrannini, hereby certify that all of the views expressed in this report accurately reflect our personal views, which have not been influenced by considerations of the firm's business or client relationships.

Unless otherwise stated, the individuals listed on the cover page of this report are analysts in Goldman Sachs' Global Investment Research division.

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